Parshas Ki Tavo

Coming In with Gratitude

Bikkurim · Safek and Simcha · Har Gerizim · Hakaras HaTov

I. Going Out, Coming In

This week's parsha opens with ki tavo el ha'aretz, when one comes into the land. Last week, in Ki Teitzei, we read ki teitzei, when one goes out. The difference between the two is meaningful. Going out is about facing the world, meeting its challenges and tests. Coming in is about arrival, reflection, and gratitude.

Going out focuses on action: how one behaves, treats others, and upholds Torah values under pressure. Coming in is about pausing, reflecting, and taking stock of how one has acted. It is a moment to recognize what has been achieved and to feel gratitude for the gifts and guidance that made it possible.

II. Bikkurim: Personal Gratitude

The parsha begins with the mitzvah of bikkurim, bringing the first fruits to the Beis HaMikdash, the seven species special to Eretz Yisrael: wheat, barley, grapes, figs, pomegranates, olives, and dates.

The mitzvah is not just about giving thanks in general. It is personal. Imagine a child saying, thank you Dad, for this chocolate. If the chocolate was random or purchased without thought, the thanks is polite but distant. But if the child thanks the parent for something made or carefully chosen, a meal, a snack, a day planned just for them, the gratitude is personal, heartfelt, and meaningful. Bikkurim works the same way. It transforms thanks into a recognition of Hashem's care and the specialness of the gifts received.

Joy is also connected to clarity. The Gemara teaches that happiness grows when doubt is removed. Midrashically, the letters of safek add up to the same gematria as Amalek, both equaling 240. Doubt creates a space for Amalek to enter. Removing doubt allows true joy to flourish. When there is no safek, there is joy.

III. Victory That Matters

The parsha reminds us that true victory is not just about overcoming the outside world. Real success is measured by how one behaves along the way, with integrity, compassion, and restraint. Coming home after challenges is not about survival or results alone. It is about reflecting on conduct and ethical growth.

IV. Har Gerizim and Har Eval: Choosing Blessing

Later, the Torah describes standing on Har Gerizim and Har Eval for blessings and curses. One mountain is fertile and green, the other more barren. The division teaches that blessings and warnings are real, and perspective matters.

The Mitteler Rebbe's experience during the reading of the Tochacha illustrates this profoundly. According to Chassidic accounts, he fainted when the rebuke was read, not because the content was new to him, but because his father, the Alter Rebbe, was absent at that moment. Normally the Alter Rebbe's presence provided guidance and context, allowing the teachings to be received with clarity and calm. Without that stabilizing influence, the intensity of the words became overwhelming.

This story teaches that the experience of rebuke and reflection is deeply relational. When self-examination has already been undertaken, even harsh words become constructive. Rebuke is transformed from fear into guidance, offering a path toward ethical refinement. It also reminds us that presence, guidance, mentorship, and proper context are crucial in spiritual growth.

V. Gratitude for Life in Eretz Yisrael

Toward the end of the parsha, the focus turns to deep, personal gratitude, hakaras hatov, for the gift of living in Eretz Yisrael. There is clarity about friends and foes, and a sense of safety in knowing who one can trust. This allows for reflection and thanksgiving, especially in contrast to situations elsewhere.

Recently in the United States, someone was murdered simply for speaking his mind, for encouraging others to think and engage in discussion. Torah law recognizes that

disagreements exist and that good and bad are not always clear-cut. But it strictly prohibits taking the law into one's own hands. Individuals are never judge, jury, and executioner. The Torah, especially in Parshas Shoftim, lays out proper process, witnesses, and courts.

This contrast highlights the blessing of living in a land and society where personal safety and ethical structure are supported. It deepens gratitude for the gift of Eretz Yisrael and reinforces the lesson of bikkurim: acknowledging and celebrating the gifts that Hashem provides. The ability to live safely, reflect, and act with integrity becomes a core part of personal thanks in Ki Tavo.

VI. Offering Personal First Fruits

As Elul continues and Selichos approach, the parsha encourages bringing personal first fruits, the best of oneself, to Hashem. Reflect on the past year. What went well? Where is there room to grow? Remove doubt by resolving unresolved conflicts or uncertainties. Offer personal gratitude for specific blessings: guidance, achievements, relationships, protection. Share that gratitude with family, community, or congregation. Recognizing these gifts strengthens the connection to Hashem and makes joy tangible.

Ki Tavo invites reflection and gratitude. After the challenges of going out, it is time to come in and take stock. Joy comes when doubt is removed, clarity prevails, and one recognizes the gifts of life. Gratitude is personal, relational, and deeply connected to everyday life. This parsha reminds us that the best way to celebrate life's blessings is through awareness, integrity, and heartfelt thanks, truly bringing the first fruits of one's actions, reflections, and experiences back to Hashem.

חזק ואחזק

Shabbat Shalom

Reflection Questions

> - *Is there a place in my life where I am going out, facing challenges, without ever pausing to come in and reflect on how I actually handled them?*

- *What is one specific gift in my life right now that deserves personal, bikkurim-style gratitude rather than a generic thank you?*
- *Where does unresolved doubt, safek, in my life right now create an opening for negativity rather than joy?*
- *Who in my life provides the kind of stabilizing presence the Alter Rebbe provided for the Mitteler Rebbe, helping me receive difficult feedback with clarity rather than being overwhelmed?*
- *As Elul approaches, what first fruits, the best of what I have done this year, do I want to bring back to Hashem?*
- *What does hakaras hatov for living where I live, with the people around me, actually look like in concrete terms this week?*